The Modern Fourth Way

A Practical Workbook for Waking Up —
and Discovering What You Actually Are

Jeremy Simon

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Contact: info@modernfourthway.org

A Note Before We Begin

This book was written to help — and I want that help to start on this page, before anything else.

If you are in crisis right now, or if you're having thoughts of harming yourself, please don't try to work through it alone, and please don't wait. In the United States, call or text **988** (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or text **HOME to 741741** (the Crisis Text Line). Outside the US, you can find your country's helplines at **findahelpline.com**, or call your local emergency number. Reaching out for help is not weakness. As this book will say again later, in its own way: it is the work itself.

Some chapters ahead touch on difficult territory — suffering, loss, death, and what may lie beyond it. If you're carrying something heavy while you read, go gently, take what serves you, and let real, live human support be part of your path. No book replaces that. This one doesn't try to.

A note on contact. If you WORK with this material — actually run the experiments, keep the notebook, walk the program — and something genuine opens up or gets stuck along the way, I'd be glad to hear about it: **info@modernfourthway.org**. A few honest limits, so the address stays useful for the people it's meant for: I read what arrives, but I can't promise a reply to every message, and the replies that do come may take time. I'm not able to provide personal guidance or crisis support by email. For crisis support, please use the resources above — they are staffed by people trained for exactly that, and they can do for you what an email address cannot.

With that said: welcome. I'm glad you're here.

Introduction

Stop for a moment, and take an honest look at your life, as it is, right at this moment. Is it overflowing with love? Are you filled with peace, and a sense of deep meaning, fully connected to everyone and everything around you? If the answer is genuinely yes, then you can put this book down — you don't need it. If not, that's okay. I want you to know two things. First, it isn't your fault. No, really — NONE of it is your fault, no matter what you may have done or not done in the past. You are exactly where you need to be at this very moment, and your past has brought you here. Second, what was just described IS possible for you. Yes, you — the one reading these words right now. This book can show you how.

Before we begin, a few words about how to work with this book — because how you read it matters as much as what's in it.

First, and most important: **you don't have to believe a single thing in these pages.** This is not a creed, and I'm not asking for your faith. I mean for you to test everything here, not believe it. When I make a claim, don't take my word for it. Treat each description as an experiment to run in the laboratory of your own direct experience. Look and see if it's true for you. If it isn't, set it down. Belief is secondhand. What we're after is FIRSTHAND.

This book brings together two great streams of teaching, and it's worth knowing that from the start. The first is the **Work** — the practical psychology brought from the East to the West a century ago by George Gurdjieff, recorded by P. D. Ouspensky, and carried forward by J. G. Bennett and others. (Throughout this book, "the Work," with a capital W, means this teaching and the practice of it.) It is a teaching about the *path*: a precise anatomy of the human machine, an explanation of why we live most of our lives on autopilot — a condition the Work calls "sleep," which Chapter 1 will define carefully — and the exact methods for waking up inside an ordinary life. No monastery required. The second stream is the **direct path** — the recognition, testified to by the mystics of every tradition and

every age, of WHAT you actually are: the truth that the awareness reading these words was never born, never separate, and never anything other than the one reality wearing all these faces. The first stream without the second becomes endless self-improvement — a better-running machine with no one home. The second without the first tends to become a beautiful idea — a truth agreed with rather than lived. Together, they are one teaching: the path, and the home it leads to. And the first stream gives this book its name. This is the Fourth Way — translated for the life you actually live, stripped of nothing essential, and walked all the way through to what it was always FOR.

One more thing about that name before we begin, because it was chosen honestly. There's a good reason it's called "the Work." You have to actually make the effort to wake up. It requires real effort and real work, applied over a long period of time. You have to actually DO the practices, not just think about them. Reading this book will give you a map — and a map, studied for a thousand hours, moves you exactly nowhere. Everything in these pages is built for DOING, and it will give back precisely as much as you put in.

And one note about the word "workbook" in this book's title, because it's a promise, not a decoration. The record of this teaching was written a century ago. This book is the MANUAL — everything in it is meant to be used: verified in your own experience, practiced in your actual life, carried into your ordinary days. If you only read it, it will not work. That's not modesty. That's the operating principle of the entire teaching, and you'll meet it again and again in the pages ahead.

A word about words themselves, because they cause endless trouble. Throughout this book I use terms like *consciousness, awareness, presence, the center, the source, the dream,* and sometimes *God.* Please understand that these are all fingers pointing at the same moon. They're pointers, not the thing itself — and no word ever could be the thing itself. If one of them trips you up, swap in another. If "God" carries baggage for you, cross it out and write "awareness." If "awareness" feels too cold, write "love," or "life," or "THIS." Don't get snagged on the vocabulary. Look where it's POINTING.

And because two streams flow through this book, two vocabularies flow through it too — and they often name the same thing. When the Work says you are *asleep* (living on autopilot, absent from your own experience) and the direct path says you are lost in *the dream* (mistaking the story in your head for reality), they mean one condition. When you read *self-remembering*, *presence*, *being here*, and *the witness*, they are four angles pointing at one capacity. I have deliberately kept both vocabularies rather than flattening them into one, because seeing two traditions converge on

the same discovery in different words is itself part of the evidence — and in Part VIII, where the second stream takes center stage, I'll tie its language back to the Work's, term by term. Every technical term in this book is defined when it first appears, and gathered again in a glossary at the back. If a term ever feels unfamiliar, trust the pointing, not the word — and check the glossary.

Here's how the book is built. It moves in eight parts. Parts I through VII cover the Fourth Way — the Work — from start to finish. First, **The Situation**: an honest look at where we are, why we feel incomplete, the problem of words themselves, and the four ways humanity has found through. Then **The Machine**: the anatomy of the human instrument — its foods, its centers, their parts, your own type, the hidden habit at the center of it all, and the crowd of "I"s that takes turns running the whole show. Then **The Core Practices**: the actual methods, the heart of the matter. Then **The Laws**: the two great principles that govern why every effort bends and how to make yours hold — and the remarkable diagram that draws them both at once. Then **Transformation**: the alchemy by which presence changes what a life is made of, and the complete toolkit. Then **Living It**: bringing the Work into daily work, relationships, suffering, and the whole of ordinary life. Then **The Edge of the Map**: where the Work, by its own admission, hands you to something beyond itself. And finally, **Part VIII — The Direct Path**: the second stream in full — what you actually are, what reality ultimately is, and how it all connects back to everything the Work has taught you.

One note about **Part VIII.** It wanders into deep water — the nature of consciousness, the origin of the universe, the illusion of separation. Some readers love that territory. Others find it too abstract, at least at first. So here is my explicit permission: **if Part VIII doesn't land for you, set it down.** The Work in Parts I through VII stands entirely on its own and asks you to believe nothing. You can always come back to the deeper material later, if and when you're drawn to it — or never. It won't cost you a thing.

A suggestion about HOW to read this book, borrowed from the tradition's source. At the front of his own magnum opus, Gurdjieff placed a piece of "friendly advice": read it three times. The first time, read the way you already read everything — mechanically, like a newspaper — just getting the general lay of the land, without trying to fully understand anything. The second time, read as if you were reading aloud to another person — every word and every sentence, carefully, at speaking pace. And only on the third reading, try to fathom the full meaning of what is written. I pass the same advice along for this book, and not as a formality. The first pass gives you the whole map at once. The second lets the language actually

land — you cannot skim aloud. And by the third, something better than rereading happens: the later chapters will have taught you how to read the earlier ones, because this book is built as a spiral, and a pass through Chapter 1 with Part VIII behind you is a different Chapter 1. (Notice, too, what the instruction quietly is: a first exercise. The part of you that reads on autopilot wants to read once, fast, and feel finished. Three readings, at three speeds, is already doing something the autopilot wouldn't — and this book will give that autopilot a proper name soon enough.)

And the one instruction that matters more than all the others: **reading is not the work.** You will not be changed by understanding this book. You could memorize every page and be exactly as asleep as when you started. The change — the only change worth anything — comes from *doing the practices,* again and again, over a long time. So read slowly. When you come to a practice, stop and actually try it before moving on. Put the book down often. Let it interrupt your day. A single minute of genuine practice is worth more than a hundred pages of agreeing with me.

Take your time. There's no rush, and there's nowhere to get to that you aren't already.

Let's begin.

PART I — THE SITUATION

Chapter 1 — Do You Feel Incomplete?

There is a certain kind of tiredness that sleep doesn't fix.

You know the one. You wake up after eight hours (your watch says your sleep score was fine), and something is still missing. You go through a day that is, by any reasonable measure, a good day. The work gets done. The people you love are healthy. The house is warm. And underneath all of it, there's this quiet feeling that something isn't right — like you're watching your own day happen through a pane of glass.

Most of us have learned not to talk about this. It sounds ungrateful. So instead, we optimize. We fix our sleep, then our diet, then our calendar. We buy the espresso machine that finally makes the perfect shot. We get the promotion, the house, the relationship. And each one delivers exactly what it promised — but what it promised turns out to be not quite what we were actually looking for. Psychologists even have a name for part of this: the "arrival fallacy." We arrive at the destination, and the feeling we expected to find there isn't there. But this goes deeper than misplaced expectations.

Here's the real root of it: **you were not actually there for most of it.**

I don't mean that as a metaphor, and I certainly don't mean it as an insult. It is a simple, testable claim about how human beings function, and this entire book rests on it. So let's state it clearly — and then YOU can test it for yourself, before reading another page on faith.

The Claim

About a hundred years ago, a teacher named George Ivanovich Gurdjieff began telling audiences in Moscow and St. Petersburg something that offended nearly everyone who heard it: man is asleep. Not asleep at night

— asleep right now. Walking around, holding conversations, driving cars, running companies, raising children — asleep. Asleep in the sense that the light of attention we assume is "on" all day is actually off almost all of the time. And what runs the show in its absence is a very capable machine.

Other traditions call this same condition "the dream," and I'll use both words throughout this book, because they point to the same thing. And here's something worth knowing: the dream has a birthday. The reason our condition is so hard to recognize is that we are filled with ideas and beliefs about ourselves and the world, fed to us by parents, teachers, and friends — assumptions so obvious that nobody ever questions them. (And anyone who does question them quickly gets labeled "crazy.") Chief among these assumptions: that from the moment we get out of bed until we return to it, we are awake and aware. But way back when we were small children, as soon as we were taught to think of ourselves as a "someone" with a certain name, we basically went to sleep. That name became the beginning of a dream — a story — which has continued to grow and evolve ever since. Most people live their entire lives inside that story, right up to the moment of death. Every once in a while, someone has a brief experience of waking up from it. But the moments are short, we quickly fall back asleep, and even our thoughts ABOUT the experience become just another part of the dream. (One caution, planted here on purpose: "dream" does NOT mean that life isn't real or that nothing matters. Life is real — just not in the way we think it is — and near the end of this book, a chapter is devoted entirely to that distinction. Keep it in mind as you read.)

Gurdjieff's student P. D. Ouspensky was a mathematician and journalist with very little patience for mysticism. He spent years trying to catch Gurdjieff overstating this claim. In the end, he concluded the claim was, if anything, understated. His record of those years, *In Search of the Miraculous*, is still the clearest map of the teaching. A generation later, a British scientist named J. G. Bennett — a man who ran industrial research laboratories by day — spent his whole life testing and extending these same ideas. And he was far from alone: a whole lineage of students and teachers has carried this teaching forward into the modern world, and this book draws gratefully on their work.

Notice something important: none of these men asked anyone to believe anything. That's the first thing that separates this teaching from nearly everything sitting next to it on the shelf. Gurdjieff's standing instruction was the exact opposite of faith: take nothing on my word; verify everything in yourself. This teaching stands or falls on observation. YOUR observation.

So let's start with one.

The Drive Home

Think of the last time you drove a familiar route — your commute, the school pickup, the road to the grocery store — and arrived with no memory of the drive. Not a fuzzy memory. NO memory. You were at the office. Then you were in your driveway. In between, a machine weighing four thousand pounds was piloted through traffic at lethal speeds, by you — braking, signaling, judging gaps — and you were not present for any of it.

So where were you?

You were in a conversation that happened yesterday, or one that might happen tomorrow. You were replaying something someone said, rehearsing a pitch, composing a text in your head. Somewhere on that drive, a very sophisticated machine handled the entire operation of your life while "you" — whatever that word means — were somewhere else entirely.

Now here's the uncomfortable question, the one this book will keep asking in a hundred different forms: **what if the drive home is not the exception?**

What if the drive home is actually a pretty fair sample of an ordinary day? What if most of your hours pass exactly this way — the machine running flawlessly, attention absent, and afterward a thin little summary filed away in memory as "my day"? What if that pane of glass you feel between yourself and your life is not a mood, and not ingratitude, and not a chemical imbalance — but simply the accurate perception of a fact? The fact that the one who could be present is, most of the time, simply not there.

Please don't agree with this. Agreeing is cheap, and this teaching has no use for agreement. Test it instead.

A Ten-Minute Experiment

Here's the experiment. It requires no preparation, no cushion, no app.

Decide, right now, that for the next ten minutes, you will remain aware of yourself. Not thinking ABOUT yourself — just quietly aware that you are here, sitting in this chair, holding this book, while everything else continues. Aware of the room, and aware of the one in the room. Both at once.

Set the intention clearly. Note the time. Keep reading.

If you are like every person who has ever tried this — including the mathematicians, the scientists, and the skeptics — here is what will happen. Within a minute or two, something in the text will catch your interest, or a sound outside will pull you away, or a thought will show up looking urgent,

and you will follow it. Your attention will fuse with whatever grabbed it. Self-awareness will vanish without any announcement. And eight or nine minutes later, you will suddenly come back — with a small jolt, an "oh, I was supposed to be doing something" — and realize you were gone.

That jolt is worth more than any paragraph in this book. In that one instant, you can see three things directly, in your own experience, with no teacher and no doctrine:

1. **There is a state of being present, and it is different in kind from ordinary functioning.** You tasted it, briefly, when you set the intention.
2. **You cannot sustain it.** Not because you lack discipline (your intention was sincere), but because something in the machinery actively pulls attention back in, the way water closes over a stone.
3. **You did not notice yourself leaving.** The departure was invisible. Only the return registered.

Gurdjieff's entire teaching begins in this ten-minute failure. The failure IS the data. A being who was actually awake could remain aware with divided attention at will. You cannot. Neither can almost all of the people who have spent decades at this — not for long, not reliably, not on demand. Whatever we are, we are not what we assumed.

What This Is Not

Before we go further, let's clear away what this diagnosis is NOT, because the modern world has filed some similar-sounding ideas in misleading places.

This is not a mental health claim. Sleep, in Gurdjieff's sense, is not depression, anxiety, or dissociation. It is the ordinary baseline condition of ordinary, functional, successful, happy people. If anything, the most optimized life runs MORE smoothly on autopilot, not less. Nothing in this book is a substitute for medical or psychological care where that's needed. The Work addresses a different axis entirely.

This is not self-improvement. The self-improvement industry (and it is an industry, worth billions) operates entirely within the machine. It makes the machine faster, calmer, more productive, better rested. All useful! But none of it touches the question of whether anyone is HOME. A perfectly optimized machine running with no one present is still running with no one present. It just has better metrics.

This is not quite mindfulness, either. Mindfulness as it's commonly taught — sustained absorption in the breath, the body, the present task — is a genuine discipline with genuine benefits, and it overlaps with what

this book teaches. But there is a precise difference, and Chapter 10 (Self-Remembering) is devoted to it: absorption in an object, however calm, is still one-way attention. What this teaching calls self-remembering is attention flowing two ways at once — toward the world, and toward the one attending. Most meditation, tested honestly, turns out to be a peaceful version of the drive home.

And this is not pessimism. The diagnosis only sounds bleak if you stop at the diagnosis. Gurdjieff's actual position was the opposite of bleak. The sleep is not a life sentence. You can study the machinery. And there is a practical method — old, tested, and specifically designed for people embedded in ordinary life — for waking up inside it. He called it the Fourth Way, for reasons Chapter 3 will make clear.

The Cost of Sleep

Why does any of this matter? If the machine handles the drive home just fine, why not let it handle everything?

Three answers, each one heavier than the last.

First: everything you regret, the machine did. Bring to mind the last thing you said that you wished, one second later, you could take back. Notice how it happened: the words were OUT before any decision to speak them ever occurred. Nobody consulted you. A stimulus arrived. A mechanism fired. And "you" showed up only afterward — just in time to feel the regret and compose the apology. The sharp word to your partner, the email sent while angry, the third drink, the doomscroll that ate the whole evening. Look closely at any of them and you'll find the same structure: action first, awareness after (if at all). Sleep is not a neutral condition. It leaves a trail of damage through every life.

Second: whatever you love, you are mostly missing it. Think of the people you would give your life for. How many minutes of yesterday's time with them were you actually present for — present in the way you were present for those thirty seconds of the ten-minute experiment? Once you start observing, the honest answer is devastating. The glass between you and your life is not just between you and the boring parts. It is between you and ALL of it.

Third — and this was Gurdjieff's most radical claim: a sleeping being cannot actually DO anything. Look closely at anything that seems like a choice, a decision, an act of initiative, and you'll find it was really a reaction — the machine responding to a stimulus according to its wiring, with a narrator attached who claims credit after the fact. "Man cannot do," Gurdjieff said, and he meant it literally. Right now, this claim

probably strikes you as obviously false. Good! It is the most verifiable claim in the entire system, and the chapters ahead will give you the tools to test it. And what's at stake in the testing is nothing less than this question: are you living your life, or is your life merely happening?

The Wager of This Book

So here is the wager on the table.

This book claims that the incompleteness you feel is accurate perception, not malfunction. It is the signal — faint, but persistent — of an unfinished being registering its own unfinishedness. It claims that this feeling cannot be optimized away, because circumstances don't produce it. ABSENCE produces it. And no rearrangement of circumstances can put someone home who isn't there. And it claims there is a way to work on this directly. Not by leaving your life for a monastery or a mountaintop, but right inside the commute, the kitchen, the inbox, the marriage — because ordinary life, rightly used, is not the obstacle to awakening. It is the gymnasium.

Everything in the chapters ahead — the strange anatomy of centers and their parts, the laws of three and seven, the chemistry of impressions, the practices — exists for one purpose: to make that ten-minute experiment come out differently. Not through the kind of effort you already know (that kind belongs to the machine), but through understanding precise enough to be SLY. Understanding that gets results brute discipline never could.

And one more thing belongs in the wager, because the stakes run beyond any one life. What you verified in ten minutes about yourself is true of nearly everyone, nearly all the time — drivers, voters, generals, heads of state. An entire civilization asleep at the wheel would be dangerous enough. An entire civilization asleep at the wheel and armed with nuclear weapons is something history has never survived before, because it has never had to. This is not a reason for panic — panic is just fear, and fear is the machine. It is a reason to treat waking up as something more than a private hobby.

You don't need to believe any of it. You only need to have noticed the glass, at least once — and to be unwilling to spend the rest of your life on the wrong side of it.

If that's you, turn the page.

Continue the journey

THE MODERN FOURTH WAY

A Practical Workbook for Waking Up —
and Discovering What You Actually Are

Twenty-five more chapters. Graduated practices at every step — first day, first week, first month, first year. Nine original diagrams, the complete teaching of the Law of Three and the Law of Octaves, and a 47-term glossary of the Work.

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